India manage its defense burden and lead to more satisfactory behavior from Beijing's ally Pakistan.[127] And it seemed an opportune time because of the Deng regime's domestic imperatives (including a modernization drive) and its concerns about Soviet influence in India. Desai thus approved a resumption of trade contacts between the two countries.[128]

Oksenberg worried in June that Sino-Indian relations, nonetheless, remained at a "low ebb." Desai had not taken a major initiative, and Beijing had not done much except extend an invitation to the Canton Trade Fair. The NSC staffer urged Brzezinski to probe the Chinese on "areas of mutual interest" in South Asia.[129] Carter subsequently asked Robert Goheen, the new ambassador to India, to "encourage and support the GOI in its efforts to improve its bilateral relations w[ith] Pakistan, China, Bangladesh and other neighboring countries."[130]

For Brzezinski, the China-US relationship was not in an ideal place either. With détente and the Soviet relationship the US priority, in February he had worried about "the lack of coherence" in East Asia policy and about the neglect of China. He had told Carter that Beijing was "eager" to come to the table because of concerns about "our Soviet drift." And Beijing might misperceive US-Soviet discussions about limiting competition in South Asia, the Middle East, and the Indian Ocean as "collusion." Carter had subsequently agreed to keep China in the loop on these discussions.[131]

Brzezinski had been keener than Carter to increase the pace of the Sino-US normalization process, which had stalled in the previous administration. He acknowledged that the lack of Sino-Soviet rapprochement after Mao's death had given Washington some time and space, but it would have to move soon.[132] In summer 1977, he had suggested to Carter that the documents related to Nixon's and Kissinger's overtures to Beijing would serve as a "good guide." Carter had been unconvinced. He had said the documents were interesting, but he did not share Brzezinski's "high opinion" of Nixon's approach: "Obviously he was adept at assuaging the Chinese—at the expense of Rogers, [the] American people, India, Soviets, etc. Also we were almost abject in our dealings with them."[133] Mondale had not been in a rush on this front either, turning down the idea of a visit to China as a signal to Beijing and Moscow (he had wanted to go to India instead).[134]